

Chapter 123-7

The drunk Qi Xiangui was stunned for a few seconds, then in his rage began searching everywhere for a weapon. He threw two or three vases at Gu Xingyue, but she wasn't injured.

He kept searching everywhere for tools, and somehow produced a knife from somewhere. "Come, let's try this."

"You little wench, daring to provoke me." Qi Xiangui spoke in a thuggish manner, "When I was playing with knives, you didn't even know where you were yet. I give you food and drink, and asking you to play a little piano is too much? You even want to threaten me with death? After you're dead, I'll just have another one—more obedient than you, better behaved than you, and smarter than you too. You've been sickly and stupid since you were little, nothing like my daughter! Who knows where your slutty mother got herself knocked up!"

These words made Yang Jiani roar in fury, but unexpectedly Qi Xiangui kicked her away and pointed the knife directly at Gu Xingyue's face.

Just as the knife was about to land on Gu Xingyue's face, Yang Jiani found a wrench from somewhere and smashed it directly onto his head. Qi Xiangui died on the spot.

After he died, Yang Jiani stabbed him again and again right in front of Gu Xingyue.

According to Gu Xingyue, Qi Xiangui's eyes hadn't closed yet at that time—he was in a state of "dying with eyes open."¹

Having suffered this fright, Gu Xingyue developed a fever that very night. She didn't know how Yang Jiani subsequently disposed of the body. It was only the next evening that the two had a minor argument.

Yang Jiani then threatened to kill her just like that day. Gu Xingyue was stabbed several times, and in the emergency, she dialed "1"—her friend Liang Shi's speed dial number—to have her call the police, while she herself stalled Yang Jiani.

Fortunately, she was saved because of this.

After giving this testimony, Gu Xingyue's face was as pale as paper, as if she could faint at any moment.

The police collected all this testimony and then asked Liang Shi whether she knew about the relationships within their family.

Liang Shi shook her head.

The police also learned from Gu Xingyue's testimony that Yang Jiani had shown abusive tendencies long ago, and that her biological daughter Qi Jiao had been abused to death in the same manner.

And Liang Shi was also among those who had suffered such harm, so the police asked Liang Shi about her childhood experiences.

Liang Shi answered each question.

Although the statute of limitations for these matters had already passed, and there was no direct evidence to prove Yang Jiani had done these things.

But submitting these as corroborating evidence would increase the severity of Yang Jiani's sentence.

After finishing her account, Liang Shi asked somewhat hesitantly: "Officer, if it's discovered that Yang Jiani has a mental illness, will she receive a lighter punishment?"

The police officer taking the statement was momentarily stunned, then said: "Normally speaking, that would be the case, but her situation is too special. Right now, our country places particular emphasis on domestic violence cases—it's a hot-button issue. Her sentencing should be quite severe."

After hearing this, Liang Shi let out a slight breath of relief, "That's good then."

After giving her statement, Liang Shi wanted to go into the hospital room to see Gu Xingyue, but she was resting, so Liang Shi could only wait.

When she went home that evening, Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu everything that had happened during the day. Xu Qingzhu said: "Gu Xingyue probably doesn't want to see you recently."

"Why?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu was flipping through a novel with a blue cover, one about war. She read while speaking: "To be precise, she won't want to see anyone. She arranged this plan flawlessly, using her own life as the price to obtain this chance to have Yang Jiani sentenced. She won't want any secrets to be leaked through conversations with you."

"If I were Gu Xingyue, I would do the same." Xu Qingzhu said, "Once I meet with you, no matter what state I'm in when I see you, it would arouse suspicion."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi held the opposite view, thinking that Gu Xingyue should be willing to see her.

At the very least, she would chat with her about her state of mind.

But over the following days when she went to the hospital several more times, the response she got was always that the patient was currently weak and it wasn't convenient to receive visitors.

Liang Shi, standing in the hospital corridor: "....."

In matters like this, Xu Qingzhu was always more accurate in her predictions than she was.

Meanwhile, Yang Jiani, who had been arrested and taken to the police station, did not honestly confess her crimes. She wouldn't eat or drink, and didn't say a single word.

She completely refused to cooperate with the police investigation.

It wasn't until the third day that Yang Jiani finally said to the police: "I want to see my Jiaojiao."

The police said coldly: "Qi Jiao was killed by you thirteen years ago. Where are you going to see her?"

The cold room fell into dead silence. After a moment, Yang Jiani said: "Then I want to see Gu Xingyue. Otherwise, I won't confess."

The police: "....."

By this time, Gu Xingyue's body had recovered somewhat. The police specially sent a car to bring Gu Xingyue over, and the two met through a transparent window.

Yang Jiani looked at her with a cold smile, "I really didn't expect that I had raised a tiger that would bring me disaster."²

Gu Xingyue's expression was indifferent, her face pale as paper without a trace of color. She only said coldly: "From the moment you treated Qi Jiao as your possession, you were wrong."

Hearing this, Yang Jiani suddenly roared in fury: "What did I do wrong?! She's my daughter! She belongs to me!"

Gu Xingyue: "....."

"Qi Jiao was truly pitiful." Gu Xingyue said, "She never had a life of her own."

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It was also on this day that Liang Shi felt somewhat unwell. It was probably because of the recent drop in temperature—the window hadn't been closed tightly at night, and she had been exposed to cold wind all night, leaving her dizzy and muddled.

She slept through the entire afternoon. At dusk, when red clouds filled the sky, Liang Shi poured herself a cup of warm water. Even after drinking it all in one gulp, she still felt thirsty. She raised her hand to touch her forehead but couldn't tell whether she had a fever or not.

Liang Shi gulped down a few more mouthfuls of water. She was just about to pick up her phone to ask Xu Qingzhu when she would be back, but the moment she unlocked it, a notification popped up at the top of the screen.

It was a picture sent by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi smiled, thinking to herself that this was probably the legendary telepathy between hearts?

Following that thought, she also remembered that tomorrow would be her one hundredth day in this world. From late summer to early winter, and she still hadn't completed the mission.

Perhaps... this mission couldn't be completed after all.

But it didn't matter anyway.

As Liang Shi was thinking this, she tapped open the chat window, and the picture appeared on the screen.

In that instant, the smile froze on Liang Shi's face, and her blood ran cold.

The water cup in her other hand dropped to the ground, shattering with a crash.

She enlarged the photo—it was shockingly Xu Qingzhu, bound in a dark corner!

Footnotes:

¹ **Dying with eyes open (死不瞑目):** A Chinese expression meaning to die with unresolved grievances or unfulfilled wishes, unable to close one's eyes in peace. It describes someone who dies in a state of shock, anger, or with deep regrets.

² **Raised a tiger that would bring disaster (養虎為患):** A Chinese idiom meaning to nurture a potential threat that eventually turns against you—like raising a tiger cub that grows up to attack its owner. Yang Jiani is saying she didn't expect the person she raised (Gu Xingyue) would become someone who would bring about her downfall.